

how much the groups that conventional wisdom says were oppressed and silenced and played no part in the development of the tradition... did actually contribute to Hinduism." She is not here to "deny that Sanskrit texts were almost always subject to a final filter in the hands of the male Brahmins"; she wants to "bring in more actors, and more stories, upon the stage, to show the presence of brilliant and creative thinkers entirely off the track beaten by Brahmin Sanskritists and of diverse voices that slipped through the filter." Doniger doesn't deny the White (yes, that's right) Brahmin Male who

human to be exceptional in their behaviour. "But most of the gods," as Doniger writes, "are vividly anthropomorphised. The gods are like us, only more so. They want what we want, things like marriage (and adultery), and fame, and praise. And most of the gods are closely associated with particular social classes: Agni is the Brahmin, Varuna the Brahminical sovereign, Indra the warrior, and the Ashvins the Vaishas. There are no Shudra gods in the Vedas." Doniger reads the *Rig Veda* as a manual of life and a social charter. The story of the dismembered Primeval Man is the first introduction to

EXCERPT

India is a country where not only the future but even the past is unpredictable. You could easily use history to argue for almost any position in contemporary India: that Hindus have been vegetarians, and that they have not; that Hindus and Muslims have gotten along well together, and that they have not; that Hindus have objected to suttee, and that they have not; that Hindus have renounced the material world, and that they have embraced it; that Hindus have oppressed women and lower castes, and that they have fought for their equality. Throughout history, right up to the contemporary political scene, the tensions between the various Hinduisms, and the different sorts of Hindus, have simultaneously enhanced the tradition and led to incalculable suffering.



"whispers into the ears of kings" his supremacy in the Hindu hierarchy. She denies him his singularity as the protagonist of Hindu magical realism. Doniger's alternative history is inhabited by, apart from the Big B of the Hindu class system, outcasts, women and animals (particularly horses, dogs and cows.)

In a brilliant rereading of the *Rig Veda*, she shows how gods, humans and animals form a powerful symmetry. It is an alliance kept alive by violence and sacrifice. The Vedic stories are not just moral fables, and even the gods are too

the class structure: the mouth becomes the priest (the Brahmin), the arms the Raja (the Kshatriya), the thighs the commoner (the Vaishya), the feet the servant (the Shudra). The Brahmin is placed below the king. "The supremacy of Brahmins was much contested throughout later Hindu literature and in fact may have been nothing but Brahmin supremacy," she writes. When Doniger reads the Veda, the marginalised—man or beast—takes centre stage.

The narrative sweep is epic. She shuttles between the worlds of the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata* to bring out the subtleties of *dharma*. She takes a ride in the chariot of the *Gita* to make sense of the concept "*karma* without

kama" (action without desire). She listens to the Tantric mantras to understand the ideas of good and evil, of death and salvation. She even goes on an exhilarating picnic in virtual Hinduism. The most rewarding parts in the book are her deconstructions of stories that lead us to the freedom of the Hindu. Every myth in this book is a social treatise, and every character refreshingly human. Even the gods are fallible. Every religion is built on a story. Wendy Doniger, with exceptional brio, tells us how the story of Hinduism continues to multiply. ■